

America's Allies

To allay public concerns about the US “going in alone,” President Johnson engineered a multinational coalition to fight in South Vietnam. When allied support for the war began to wane, US and South Vietnamese soldiers ended up providing most of the manpower.

◀◀ BEFORE

The formation of the United Nations (UN) in 1945 offered the promise of world peace by enabling nations to resolve their differences without violence.

COLLABORATIVE FAILURE

Since 1948, the UN's peacekeeping force, composed of **troops volunteered by member nations**, has been used to suppress noncompliant armed forces in conflicts around the world.

The biggest obstacle to the UN stepping in to prevent the Vietnam War was that the Soviet Union and the United States, both members of the UN Security Council, with the power to veto resolutions, **supported opposing sides** in the war. Attempts by the United Nations to resolve the conflict through negotiation failed.

General Westmoreland's strategy of attrition required steady increases in troop strength. Believing that other countries should contribute to the fight against communism, in the summer of 1965 President Johnson pressed US allies around the world to support the war effort.

France objected to foreign intervention in Vietnam. Great Britain and Canada offered only rhetorical support, and Spain sent about 50 soldiers; other nations provided economic, technical, and medical aid to South Vietnam.

The Johnson administration fared better with regional allies, who feared communism's international advance. The mutual defense provisions of the Southeast Asia Treaty Organization provided formal justification for Australia, New Zealand, Thailand, and the Philippines to send troops to South Vietnam, while general support of US regional interests led the Republic of Korea (the ROK) to support American efforts.

Soldiers from these nations were known collectively as “Free World Military Forces” (FWMF) and they fought in support of both US and ARVN efforts in South Vietnam.

91 PERCENT of South Vietnam's regional allies came from South Korea.

6 PERCENT came from the Philippines and Thailand.